



Contemporary · director of the Stanford Digital Economy Lab.

"The benefits lag the investment by years."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Brynjolfsson has spent his career on a single puzzle: why transformative technologies often fail to show up in productivity statistics for years before delivering large gains.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

His empirical work on IT and, later, AI established that realising value requires heavy investment in complementary intangibles — skills, processes, data and organisational change.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Productivity J-Curve and informs the Intangible Capital Iceberg in Unit 2's treatment of AI benefits.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His ideas operationalise as patience with the J-curve dip and deliberate investment in the intangible complements that create the eventual payoff.

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The J-curve is harder to apply in real time than in retrospect, and distinguishing a genuine lag from a genuine absence of value remains a judgment call.

ENDURING IMPACT

Brynjolfsson is among the most influential economists of the digital and AI economy, shaping how firms and policymakers interpret AI's economic impact.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 2)

Robert Solow · Giant 7

Everett Rogers · Giant 8

Eliyahu Goldratt · Giant 9

Dave McClure · Giant 10

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Brynjolfsson, E., Rock, D. and Syverson, C. (2021) 'The Productivity J-Curve', AEJ: Macro, 13(1).

Brynjolfsson, E. and McAfee, A. (2014) The Second Machine Age. New York: Norton.